

ments (allegedly involving Grover's wife, Madhuri Jain Grover, a NIFT graduate, who was head of controls at BharatPe). The company's investors (and that list has some very eminent names) ought to have known what was going on. As things stand, there are far too many questions lying unanswered.

LAST JULY, BharatPe did something quite extraordinary. It gave out high-end BMW bikes to new recruits or they could go for an expensive gadget, as joining bonus. Such bonuses are a norm in the industry, but not goodies of this kind. Grover's personal life was no different. He owns at least three luxurious homes in the capital (valued at over ₹20 crore each) apart from a car collection that has a Porsche Cayman, an Audi A6, a Mercedes-Maybach S 650 and also a Mercedes-Benz GLS 350. Pictures of him and his spouse are splashed liberally in social media. To at least one generation of Indians, Grover was a role model—the boy who grew up in middle-class Delhi and studied at IIT Delhi before going to IIM Ahmedabad. He was rich, owned a fancy fintech company, and was the person to emulate.

BharatPe, too, loosened its purse strings at the drop of a hat. In October 2020, the company launched the Team BharatPe television campaign. Directed by Punit Malhotra, known for Hindi movies such as *I Hate Luv Storys* and *Student of the Year 2*, it had 11 cricketers as its brand ambassadors—including Indian cricket captain Rohit Sharma, K.L. Rahul, Jasprit Bumrah and Ravindra Jadeja. A year earlier, it had popular actor Salman Khan as brand ambassador. With Grover, there was never a dull moment. Only one thing obsessed him—growth, at a frenetic pace.

In October 2018, BharatPe had just raised \$2 million, with Beenext Capital and Sequoia Capital India as lead investors. It was not a huge amount,



“Grover’s ouster/ resignation would not impact the company operations or its execution plans, but there could be normal fund-raise challenges and valuation may get subdued in the near term”

K. GANESH
SERIAL ENTREPRENEUR AND
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PORTEA MEDICAL AND
HOMELANE

and it seemed like a good time for Grover to get in some more money. One venture capitalist (VC) *Business Today* spoke to, recalls meeting Grover during that period. Grover's need was around ₹3 crore. The VC recalls Grover liberally using Sequoia's name to push BharatPe's cause: “They are fully backing me. You will not lose your money.” Having seen many a business plan in his career, the VC asked for time to think. “I am giving you no more than two days to decide. *Chinta mat kar, kyunki tere liye paisa bana doonga* (don't worry, I will make money for you),” was the retort from Grover. It was “quite crazy”, the VC recalls. “We were extremely uncomfortable with that kind of aggression. BharatPe was a small entity, but Ashneer's confidence bordered on cockiness, and we did not go ahead.”

Often, his brashness landed Grover in trouble. Top it up with an insatiable desire to be visible or even dominate, and you have a very potent concoction. Take the case of grocery delivery start-up Grofers, where he was the CFO. A former Grofers official says it hurt him that the founders—Albinder Dhindsa and Saurabh Kumar—were constantly in the limelight: “No one from the outside world knew Ashneer and he could not deal with that.” In his letter to the BharatPe board where he said he was resigning as MD and Director, Grover said he helped build Grofers from scratch. “That's a bit strange since he was never a part of the founding team,” says the same person.

Equally confounding was the decision to move to PC Jeweller to take over as head of new business in November 2017, before moving out a year later to become CEO and Co-founder of BharatPe. His LinkedIn profile eloquently mentions “leading digital transformation and strategy at the second largest jewellery retailer in India”. Why he chose to join PC Jeweller, not really a big name, is hard to understand.

BharatPe followed right after. The

**\$2
MILLION**

The amount raised by BharatPe in October 2018, with Beenext Capital and Sequoia Capital India as key investors